of the different resumes prepared by a candidate might be roughly the same, but the organisation, format, structure, and emphases could be quite different.

Whatever the resume design, the resume must answer the following questions.

a. How can the employer contact the candidate?
b. What are his/her career objectives?
c. Which institution has he attended?
d. What courses has he completed?
e. What is his/her work experience?
f. What are his/her career achievements?
g. What are his/her special skills or capabilities?
h. What are his/her awards or honours?
i. What are his/her activities, special interests, or hobbies?
j. Who are his/her references?

While preparing a resume the applicant should keep these questions in mind. Answers to these questions will provide the employer with all the relevant information needed to asses an applicant's suitability for a particular position.

ADVANTAGES OF A RESUME

A resume is highly useful. An applicant may use it to accompany a letter of application, present it to an employer at the interview, mail it to a prospective employer without a formal letter of application, or use it to assist him in filling out an employment application form. There are certain advantages of preparing bio-data sheet.

1. It is in outline form and can be treated as a complete documentation of the applicant's record.

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2. It is prepared in a way that makes it convenient for the employer to select from it the facts he desires.
3. The applicant can easily duplicate it for enclosure with both solicited and unsolicited letters of application.

PARTS OF A RESUME

The standard parts of a resume include the heading, position sought, career objective, education, work experience, specific skills, achievements, activities, interests, and references.

Heading

The heading of a resume includes contact information, which contains the applicant's name, full postal address, telephone numbers, fax number, and e-mail address.

Position Sought

If the applicant is applying for a solicited job position, the position sought should be mentioned so that the employer is able to distinguish the application from those who might have applied for other positions available in the organisation. However, it is not necessary to include this part in the resume if the application is for an unsolicited job position.

Career Objective

Career objective is a special part in a resume. It occurs just above the education and experience parts. Objective should be a specific one-sentence focused statement expressing applicant's career goals in relation to the targeted position. It should convey his motivation and interest in the job he is seeking. For example,

1. To work as a product manager in a multi-national pharmaceutical company where I will be able to use my experience in the area of product development, and

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impart knowledge about product in training sessions.

2. To work as a management trainee in an industry where my education in management, with a major in marketing, may be developed and ultimately to be a senior executive in marketing.

The applicant may use a general statement as his career objective. It would just express his general career goals and tell the employer the sort of work he is hoping to do; e.g.

1. Seeking a suitable position in project management.
2. Challenging position in supervising sales team.
3. A management position in accounts.
4. Sales position in electrical products.

Education

In this part of the resume, specific details regarding the applicant's education and professional training must be included. The name and location of the school, college, university, or institute attended, dates of attendance, major areas of study, degrees/certificates received should be mentioned. The applicant's grade point average, class, division if it is on the higher side may also be mentioned. Relevant training programmes, special courses, seminars and workshops that the applicant has attended or conducted should also be included. Reverse chronological order is usually used to list educational information, that is, starting from the most recent educational information.

Work Experience

This part of the resume should provide a brief and specific overview of the applicant's work and professional experience. As prior work experience is a vital part of any hiring decision, the applicant must draft this part of the resume very carefully. If he has impressive work experience relevant to the position he is seeking, it is better to mention it before providing the educational information.

Work experience should be given in reverse chronological order, by listing the most recent employment

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first. Title of the position, employer's name or name of the organisation, location of work (town, city), dates of employment, and important job responsibilities, activities, and accomplishments should be included.

Special Skills, Abilities, and Aptitudes

In this part of the resume, the applicant's special skills, abilities and aptitudes that are of significance and of direct relevance to the job applied for are listed. These may include computer programming, data processing, foreign languages, machinery operation, and so on. It is necessary to highlight only those skills and talents that are relevant to the job applied for.

Activities and Interests

Extra-curricular, co-curricular, hobbies and interests must be mentioned in a resume. These activities must show that the applicant is a dynamic and energetic person who can accept challenges. Companies prefer such people.

Achievement, Accomplishments, Honours

The applicant's achievements, accomplishments, and awards distinguish him from the rest. They convince the employer that he is an achiever and therefore worth hiring. This part should include scholarships, awards, distinctions, commendations, certificates, or anything that shows achievement or recognition.

References

When applying for a solicited position where the employer wants references, the names of two or three persons, who can give letters of recommendations should be mentioned. These persons may include the applicant's previous employer, teacher, immediate supervisor, research guide, colleague, subordinate, and so on. The name of the reference, his designation, and full contact address with telephone number, fax number, and e-mail address should be given.

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